

When asked about a time an app had a negative impact on people, few apps come to mind quicker than the social media app Tiktok. Now this paper is not going to focus on the noticeable impacts apps like Tiktok, Instagram, and many other social media apps have had on people's mental health but rather a focus on the consequences of the Tiktok ban that was in discussion last year. This ban shook many people and impacted many small businesses who utilized the platform for advertisement.

Before going into the impacts of the potential ban, we must first understand what Tiktok is. Tiktok is a social media app similar to things like vine where users post short videos dancing to music, commentating on recent events, or many other things of that nature. It gave people a creative outlet and a way to join in communities rallying around their favorite celebrities or famous users on the platform. Importantly for today however was the many people who utilized Tiktok for advertising for their small businesses or art. They would post short videos of them showcasing what they had created and linking their store page in their bio for their accounts. This was impactful because it gave smaller businesses a chance to reach a wider audience utilizing Tiktok as its form of free marketing. But as described in lecture, if a service is free you are the product. This concerned the United States government enough that they proposed a ban for Tiktok last year. The ultimatum was to have Tiktok be sold to an American company or have it be banned. This ban went into effect last year for only around a day as current president Donald Trump pushed back the date that the company needed to be sold by to April 5th, it again was pushed back from the April 5th due date. This technology was ultimately impactful because it gave opportunity to those starting small start up businesses using Tiktok as a source of free advertising for their products.

As for the parent company who owns Tiktok, ByteDance, their response to this ban has been very interesting. Their response to this proposed bill to ban Tiktok is calling it unconstitutional citing a violation of the first amendment. ByteDance also called attention to the fact that the banning of Tiktok would result in the removal of one hundred seventy million American users as well as seven million businesses being impacted by the ban. But beyond calling the bill to ban Tiktok unconstitutional and a violation of the first amendment, ByteDance has made it clear they have no intent to sell Tiktok to an American corporation. However, they have made it clear they will sue it out to have Tiktok unbanned if it were to be banned. At one point the date passed and they had not sold Tiktok so it was banned, but only for a short while because current president Donald Trump pushed back the ban date, he has recently pushed it back again. This pushback has left users happy as they can still use the application but leaves people wondering what the purpose of the threatened Tiktok ban is if no one is going to follow through on it.

In spite of all these things ByteDance is doing to try to save Tiktok from being banned, there is not much they can do besides selling it to an American company. This is because the United States government views Tiktok as a major security risk. This is a valid claim as users who agree to the terms and service sign away their data to be tracked and sold to a non American corporation. The reason the United States government has stepped in however is because the country that ByteDance and therefore Tiktok is from is China. Because of this the United States government views ByteDance and Tiktok as a national security threat. This view of a threat is caused by the extensive data tracking utilized by Tiktok so another solution that ByteDance could have done is to roll back some of their data monitoring and collection utilized

by Tiktok. This would reduce the amount of money Tiktok makes hurting their bottom line so this is an unlikely solution but it is something they could have done.

In the end, the United States attempted ban on Tiktok shook the country in many ways. Those most impacted include those who have a small business and utilize the platform for free advertising. It also is worth noting those who simply used the app for entertainment also being impacted, losing access to the free entertainment they had grown to enjoy. The owner of Tiktok, ByteDance, attempted to manage the impact of this ban by filing a lawsuit against the United States government citing that banning Tiktok is a violation of the United States First amendment. The ban came after the United States government deemed Tiktok a national security risk. This was caused by the very intrusive data collection Tiktok has when users agree to the terms of service. Despite the cited national security risk, the United States government, specifically the Trump administration, has continually pushed the ban date back. Yet there were solutions to this issue that ByteDance could have done in order to not have Tiktok face a ban. They had 2 options to mediate this potential crisis for their users. The first being to sell Tiktok to an American based company and comply with the United States government's order. The second was to remove some of their more intrusive data collection policies in their terms of service. Ultimately, the Tiktok ban would have widespread ramifications for both the standard user but also the many small business owners on the platform utilizing Tiktok and its widespread popularity to advertise their business. Yet the most interesting thing is that this story is still ongoing due to another pushback of the ban date by the Trump administration. SO we must watch and observe what the fate of Tiktok will become.